Your Career’s Attack Surface

The Career Disruption Playbook No One Gave You

How we can use our own cybersecurity skills in our career

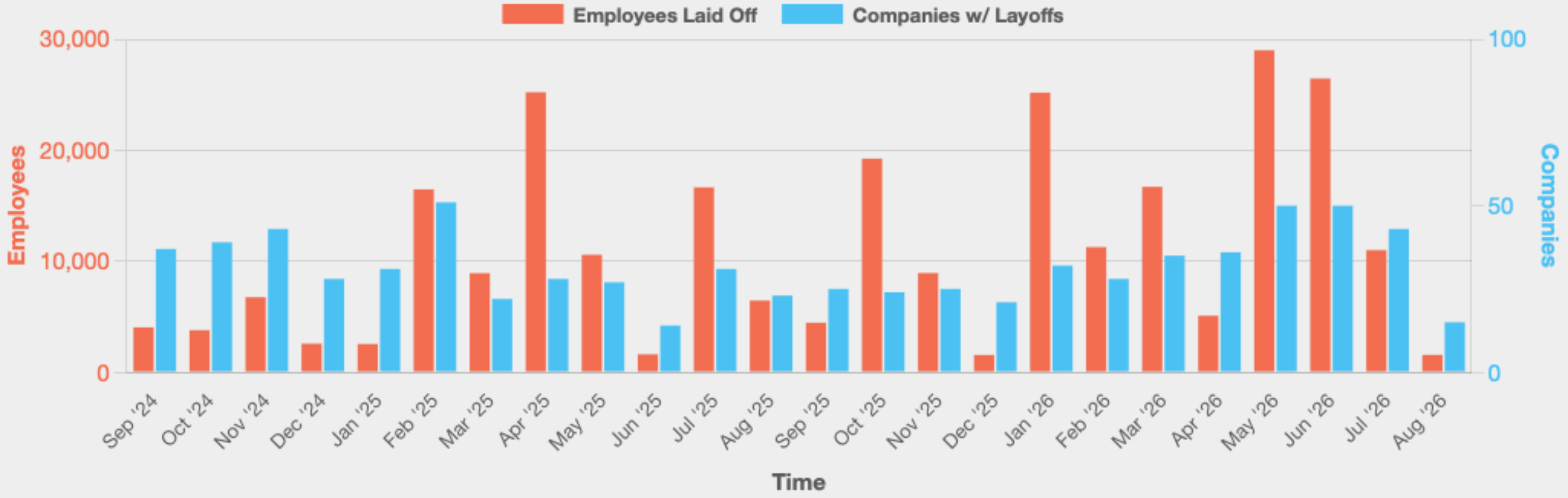


JAMES MCQUIGGAN


Sarah J. - Director of Ops
Aisha K. - HR Representative
Zoom Chat
Re: Singapore transition plan ...

Recent Tech Layoffs

Source: https://layoffs.fyi



I’m So Sorry… That Sucks!



JAMES MCQUIGGAN

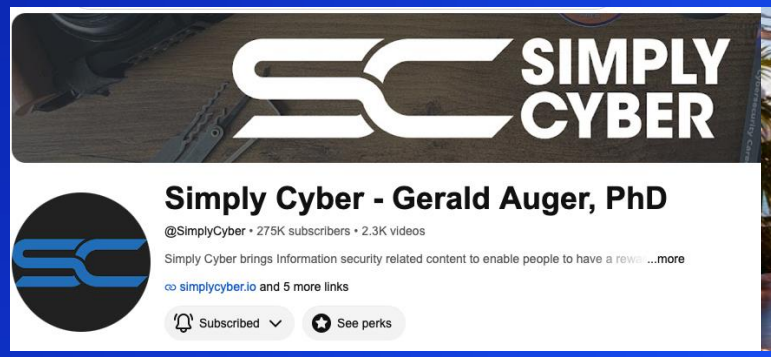
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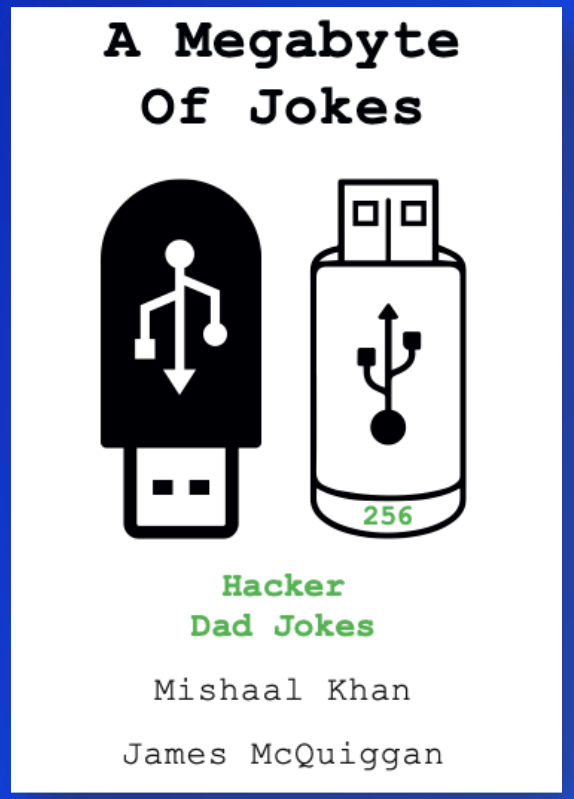
qrto.org
apparentsecurity.com

apparentsecurity



whoami

James R. McQuiggan, CISSP



My Book

qrto.org
Amazon


Oteila
Sarah J. - Director of Ops
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Zoom Chat
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Everything I've been

teaching others to do

I now had to do for myself.

What I Got Wrong

The Mistake

I was comfortable. I believed the quality of my work would speak for itself.

The Blind Spot

6 months in, my new boss had never seen my presentations, my work, or my impact.

The Lesson

Visibility is not vanity.

Managing upward is a security control.



Cybersecurity Concepts We Can Apply

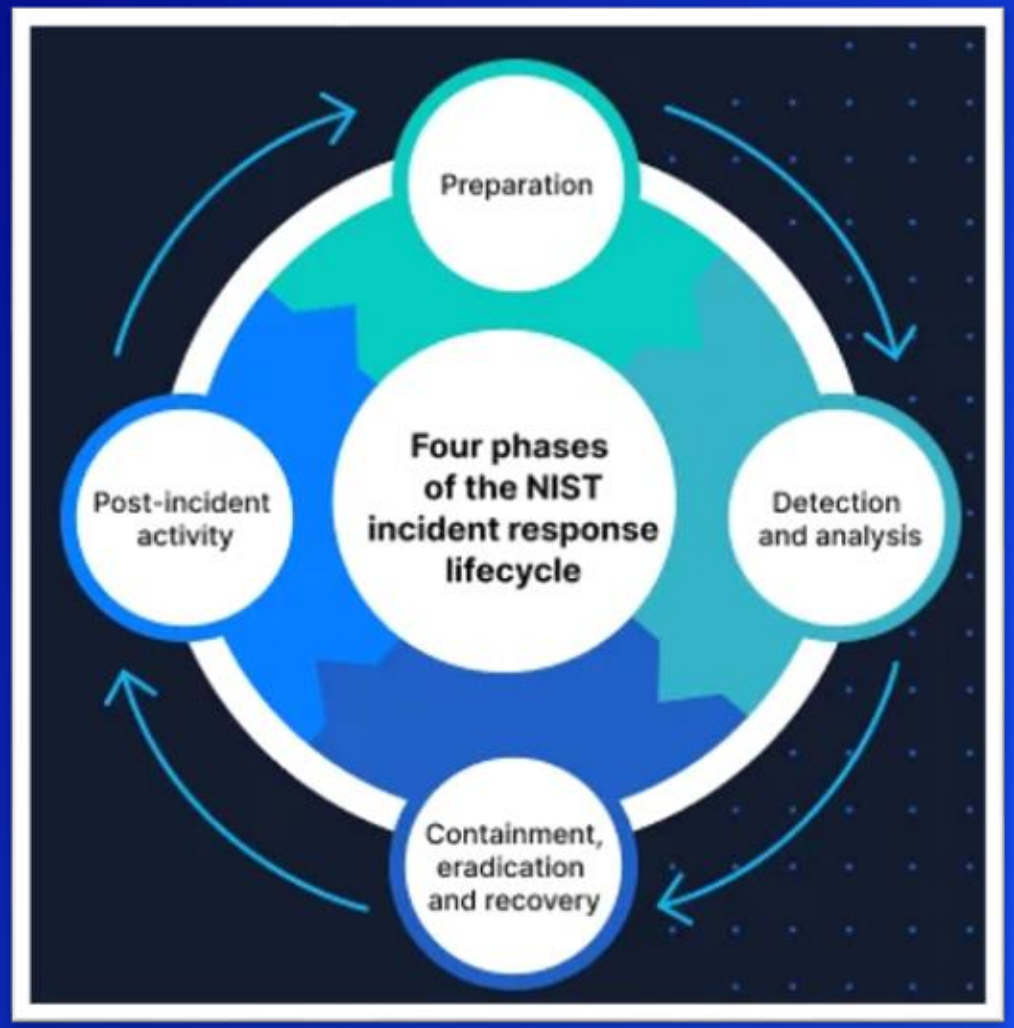




Incident Response

Activate Your Playbook On Your Cyber Career

Incident Response Plan - NIST



01

Preparation: Policies, roles, training, monitoring tools, and TTX.

02

Detection and Analysis: Monitoring logs, alerts, and CTI. Assess Incident.

03

Containment, Eradication, and Recovery: Taking action, eliminate the threat with remediation, restore systems.

04

Post-Incident Activity: Determine roots cause, lessons learned, update policies if needed.

James’ Actual Incident Response Plan



03

Containment, Eradication, and Recovery: Taking action, eliminate the threat with remediation, restore systems.

04

Post-Incident Activity: Determine roots cause, lessons learned, update policies if needed.



Using the NIST incident response lifecycle, because you already know how to run this playbook.

01

Preparation

RIF-proof your role before disruption

02

Detection & Analysis

The first 72 hours

03

Containment

Stabilize your money, mindset, and message

04

Eradication & Recovery

Pipeline access, evaluate your goals, and options

05

Lessons Learned

Land stronger than before



Preparation & Detection

The gameplan that survives any single employer, role, or org chart.

We assess everything. Except our own careers

0

vulnerability assessments most of us have ever run on our own careers.

1

meeting invite is all it takes.
No CVE, no advance disclosure.

2

hours after that notification, set your plan to recovery.

You are the unpatched system.

Your Personal Attack Surface

Single-Employer Dependency

One organization holds your entire income and identity.

Crisis-Only Network

A network that activates only in emergency is not infrastructure.

Aging Certs

Credentials without renewal signal stagnation.

No External Brand

The market doesn't know you exist until you need it to that you’re there to work!

No Impact Portfolio

If your work leaves no record, it leaves no proof.

Threat Intelligence – RIF PROOF

Visibility

Are you known inside and outside your organization? Does leadership see your work, or only the output?

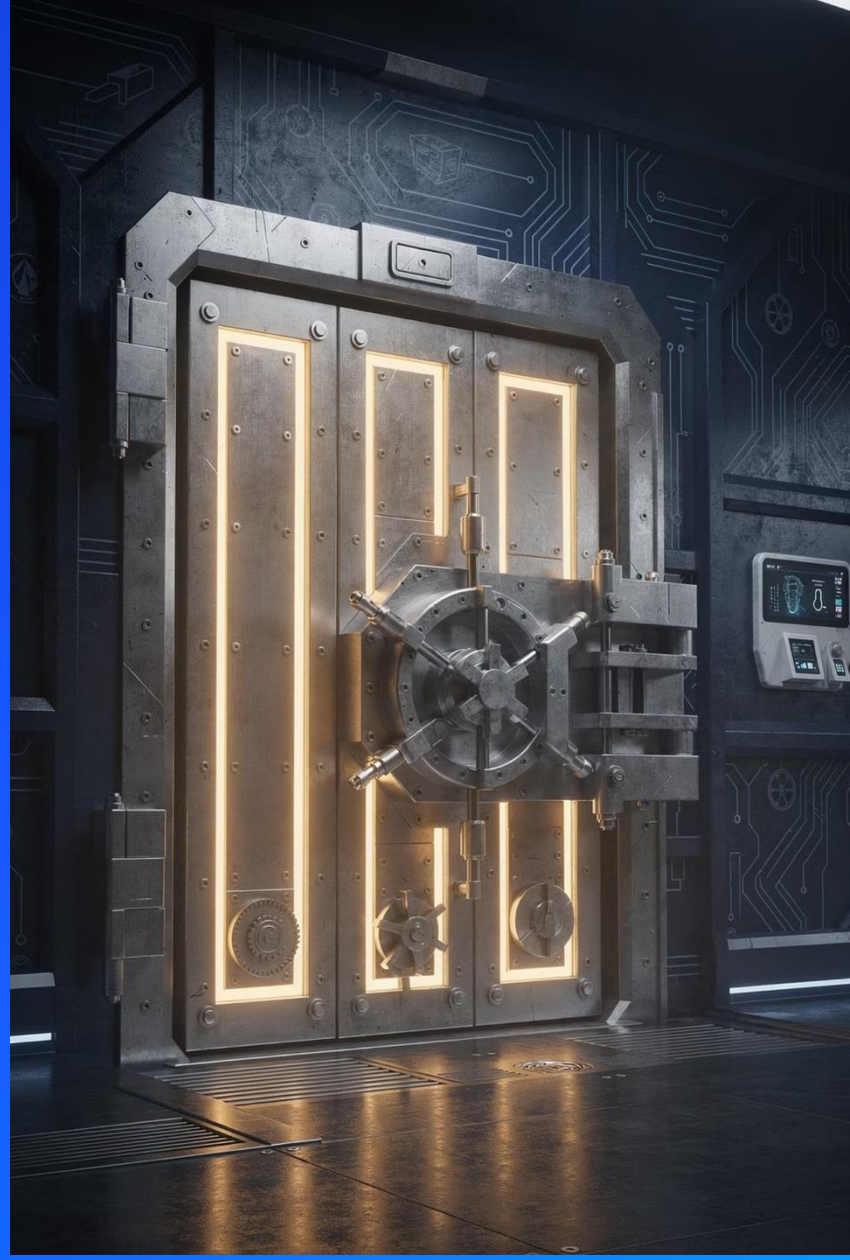
Indispensability

Is your work documented? Does it disappear when you do? If your departure leaves no trace, that's a risk signal.

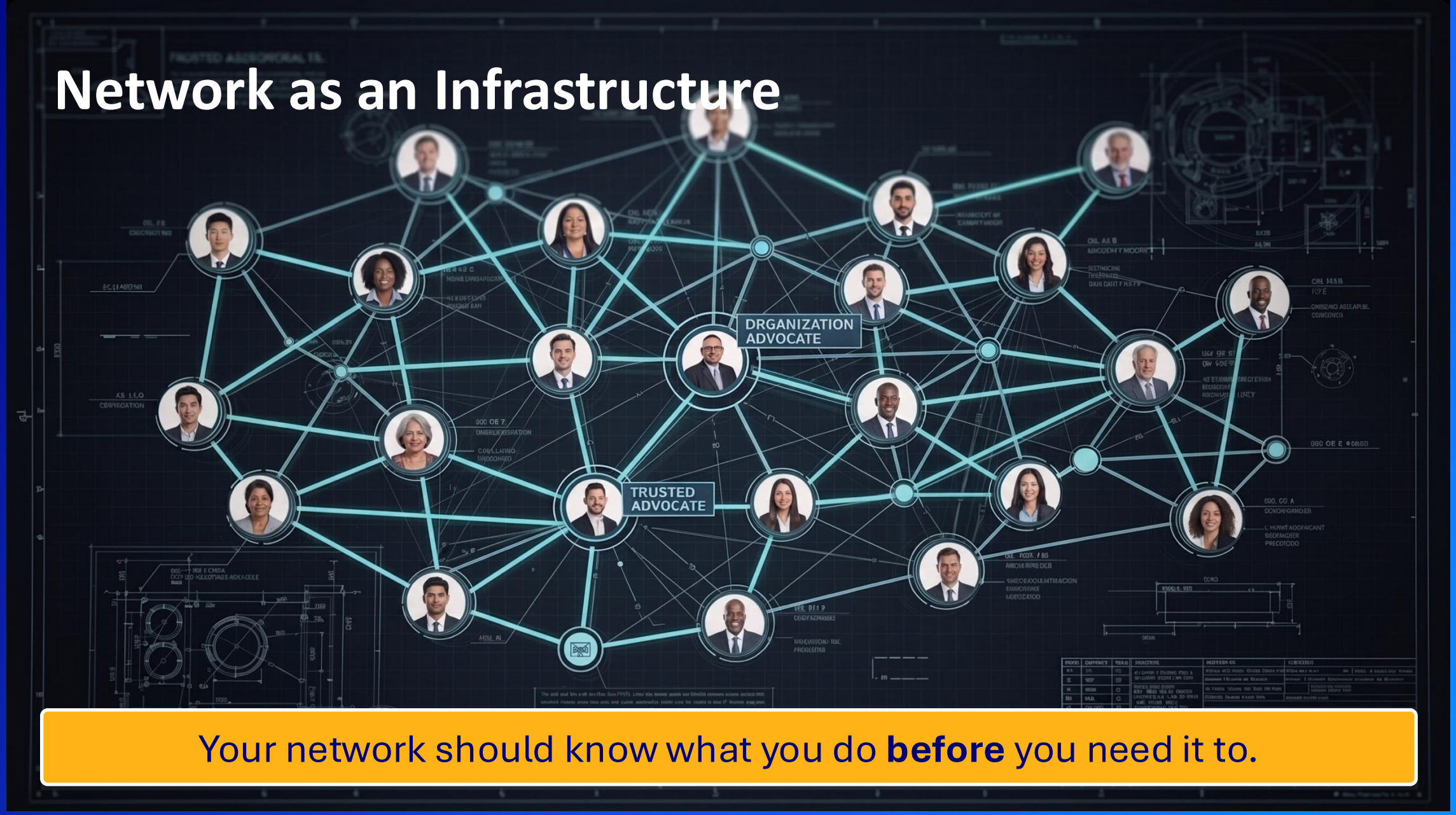
Optionality

Could you generate income from your skills tomorrow if you had to? Having options is not luxury, it's a resilience control.

LIKE SECURITY – THIS IS NOT 100% RISK FREE



Network as an Infrastructure



Your network should know what you do **before** you need it to.

Personal Brand as a Defensive Asset

Brand is not vanity. It is pre-positioning.

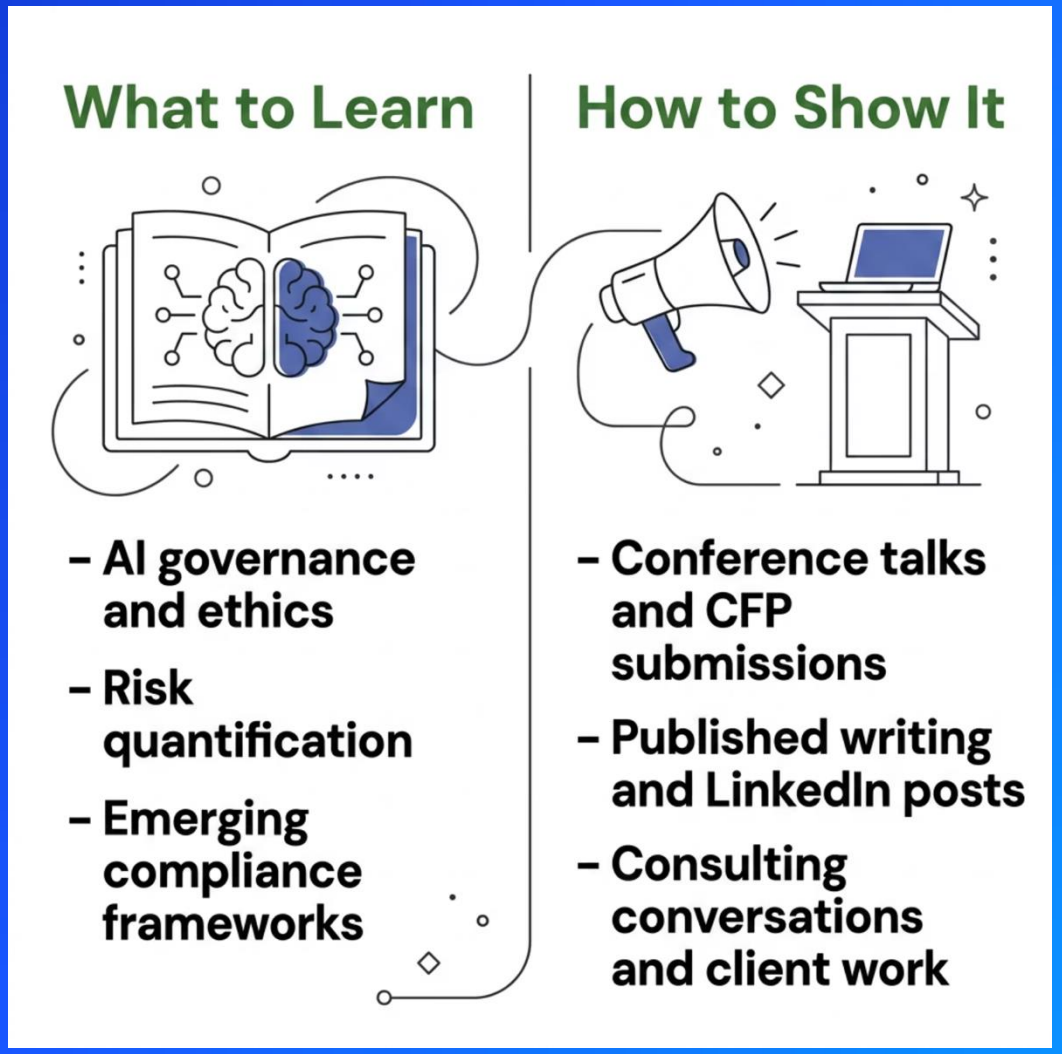
When It Helps ✓

- Produces credible conversations and warm intros
- Signals value to target employers before you apply
- Compounds over time without constant active effort

When It Hurts ⚠

- Drains execution time when runway is tight
- Vanity metrics masquerading as job search progress
- Posting to feel productive instead of actually applying

Learning that Nobody Sees, Doesn't Help Move the Needle



Build assets your employer doesn't own

Talks & podcasts

Public proof you can command a room

Writing & research

Searchable evidence of expertise

Teaching & mentoring

Credibility that compounds

Assets

Templates, runbooks, frameworks with your name on them

When the badge is deactivated, the portfolio still answers for you.

Keep a warm-standby resume

Quarterly resume refresh

Update accomplishments while they're fresh and quantifiable. Rebuilding two years of wins from memory, under stress, produces a worse document.

Know your market rate today

Talk to recruiters even when you're happy. Salary bands move; your anchor number should move with them.

Keep a brag file

Metrics, wins, kudos emails — captured the week they happen. Your future resume writes itself.

You can't build a SOC during the incident

Maintain the network while employed

Coffee chats, community, chapters, conferences.
A network activated cold is a network that underperforms.

Deposit before you withdraw

Make intros, give recommendations, answer the DMs.
The people you helped are your incident responders later.

Map your internal advocates

For every company on your someday-list, know one human inside it.
Referrals beat portals every time.

Career IoCs: detection starts before the incident

Reorgs & leadership churn

New executives bring new org charts.
Two reorgs in a year could be a signal, not noise.

Budget and hiring freezes

When the function stops growing, someone is modeling what it looks like smaller.

Your role is moving

Work drifting to another region, team, or 'center of excellence’.
Mine moved to Singapore.

You're out of the room

Left off planning meetings and strategy threads you used to be in?
Your role is being decided without you.



Detection & Analysis

It’s the First 72 Hours post RIF



Zero ~~Day~~ Hour

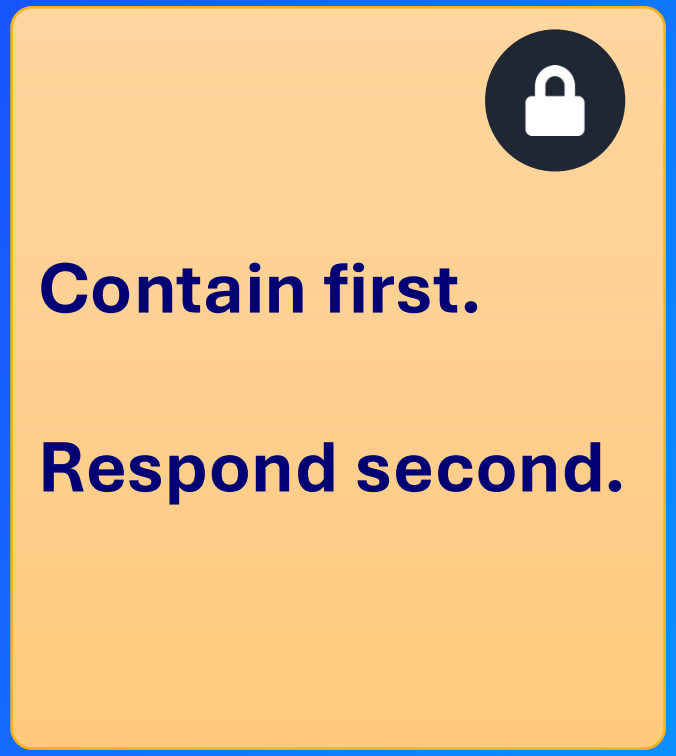
The emotional hit is real.

Don't skip past it.

“A layoff is an event. Not an identity.”

Hour 0: contain before you respond

- **Don't sign anything in the room or online – Lawyer up!**
- Severance agreements have review periods for a reason, so use them. Get everything in writing.
- Inventory the package: severance, PTO payout, equity treatment, benefits end-date.
- Solve health coverage quickly: COBRA vs. marketplace vs. spouse's plan
- File for unemployment immediately.
- Freeze discretionary spending until the cash flow is done.



Emotional Containment: Don't Let It Fester, Don't Suppress It

- It's a grief event, so treat it like one
- Tell your family the same day
- You are not your badge



5 Stages of Grief – Aligned With This RIF

Denial

“My laptop still has access … right?”

Numbness and autopilot. Replaying my actions for the past 3 months.

Anger

“It's not me, it's them.”

Angry at management, the company…

Myself.

Bargaining

“What if I'd seen it coming?”

Replaying my actions. What if I did this, what if I dd that? Renegotiating the Separation Agreement.

Depression

The identity crater.

How do I pay my bills? Take care of my family?
All of my content, gone. My connections, gone.

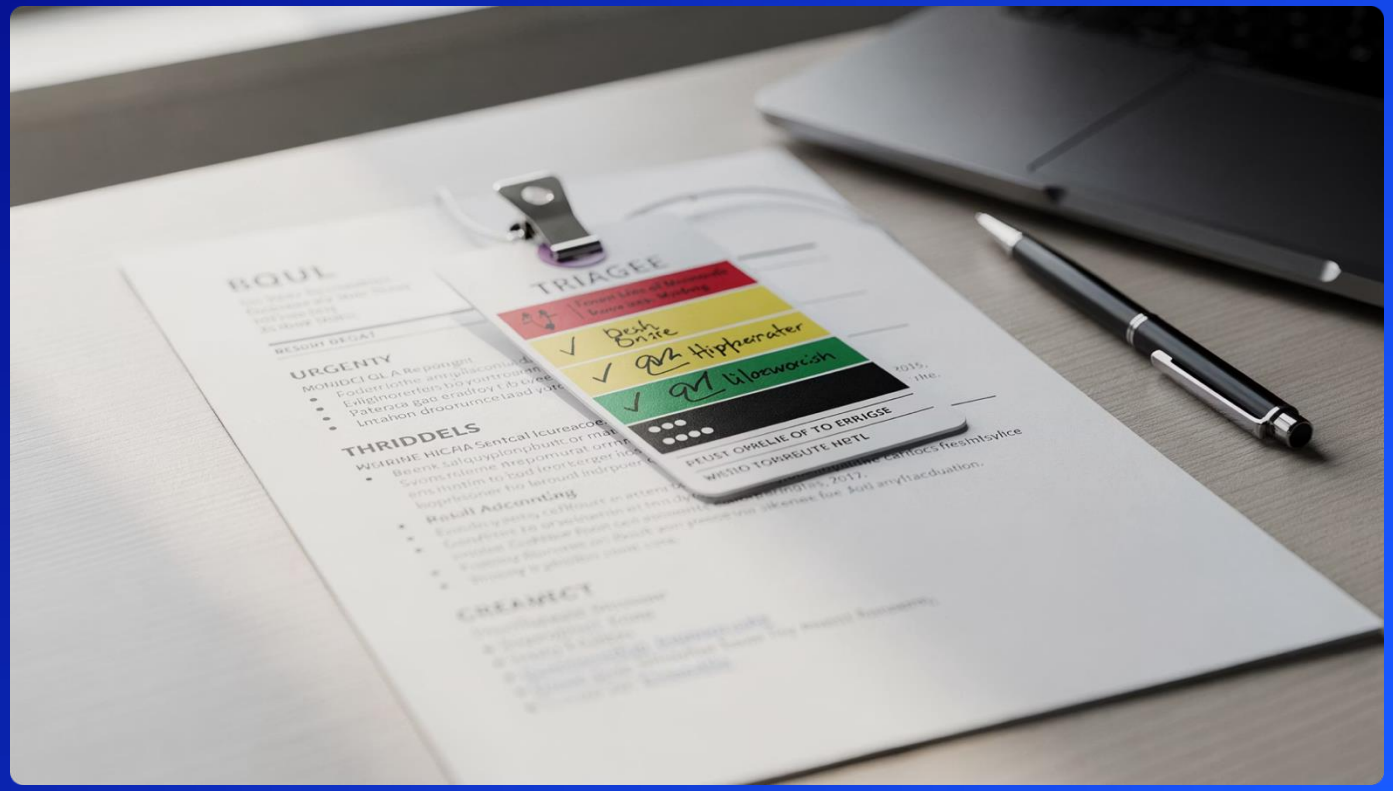
Acceptance

Not approval but action.

The incident now shifts to new work, apply for jobs, connecting with my network to find work.

Emotional Triage Is Protocol

You cannot run an incident response from a compromised state.



1. **Sleep. Exercise. Daily plan.**
2. **Talk to someone who knows you**
3. **Wait 24 hours**

Donate Your Swag



Dave Lewis

- ”It’s not you, it’s the business”
- “Get out and exercise and help release any frustration”
- “Take a yellow legal pad and draw a line down the middle. On the left, write down what you want to do. On the right, write down what you do not want to do”
- Now use that to help you find your next role



Control the Narrative — Hours 1–24

Your story is your signal. Own it before the market writes it for you.

01 — Who You Are

Clear professional identity statement not your last title

02 — Problems You Solve

Specific, repeatable value — the problems organizations pay to fix

03 — Proof of Impact

Quantified achievements that survived the transition with you

04 — The Role You Want Next

Specific enough to be actionable. Vague targets produce vague results.



Containment

Pipeline engineering where you search as a system, not a lottery

Financial Stabilization — Hours 24–72

This is not panic. This is asset inventory & your backup

Cash Flow Math

What you have. What it costs. How long it lasts. Run the numbers today

Insurance Bridge

COBRA, marketplace plan, or spouse coverage. Gaps here are expensive. Resolve within the week.

Spending Audit

Pause non-essential subscriptions and recurring charges. Protect the cash flow above everything else.



“My job is getting a new job”

Daily Structure

Set hours, get dressed, work the pipeline. Structure is the antidote to the drift that starts on day four.

One action daily

An application, an outreach, an interview, a follow-up. Every single day, something that can produce income.

One future action weekly

A talk, an article, a certification module. Keep the long game alive without letting it eat the short game.

Track everything. A daily regiment and discipline reduces emotional impact

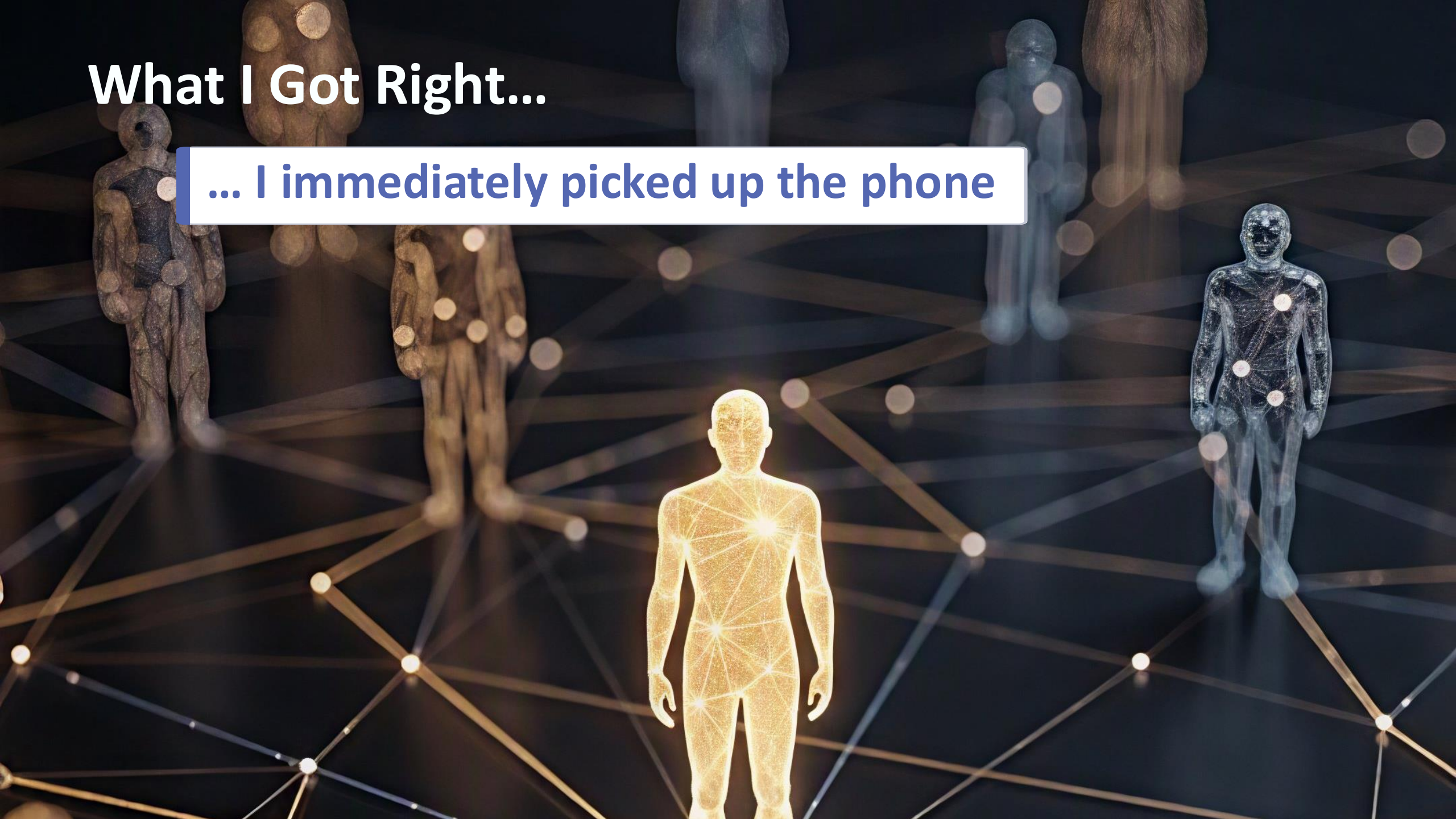


Eradicate & Recovery

Pipeline engineering where you search as a system, not a lottery

What I Got Right…

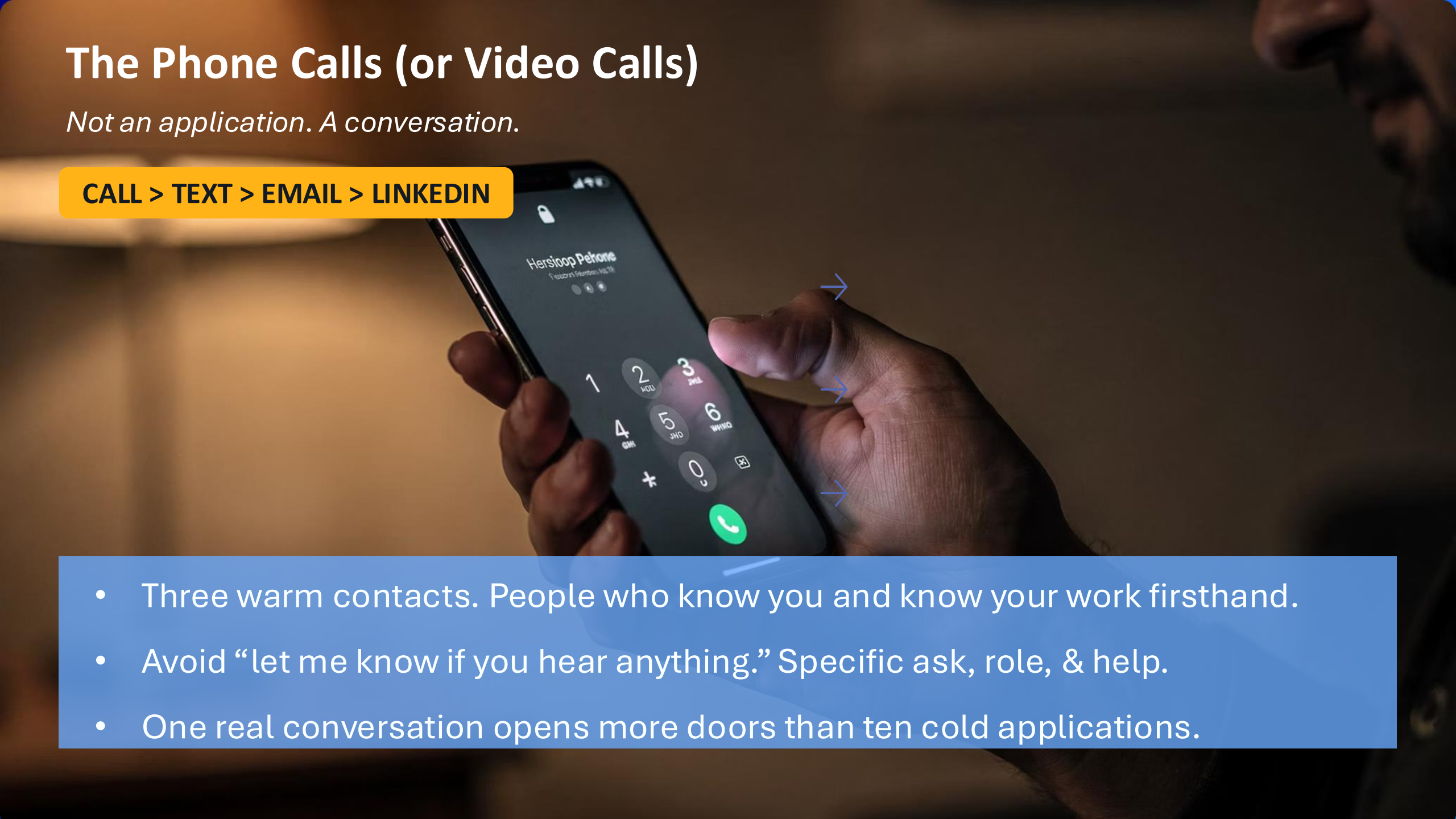
… I immediately picked up the phone



The Phone Calls (or Video Calls)

Not an application. A conversation.

CALL > TEXT > EMAIL > LINKEDIN



- Three warm contacts. People who know you and know your work firsthand.
- Avoid “let me know if you hear anything.” Specific ask, role, & help.
- One real conversation opens more doors than ten cold applications.

My Conversations (~90 days)



Getting a New Job

- Journal
- Salary Expectations
- ISACA AI Risk Training Program
- Interview Questions
- Job Opportunities
- I'm sorry, that sucks
- Resources
- Human Resiliency

Journal

- January 8
- January 9
- January 11
- January 12
- January 13
- January 14
- January 15
- January 16
- January 26
- January 27
- January 28
- January 29
- January 30
- Feb 2 - Feb 12
- Feb 13
- Feb 17
- Feb 18
- Feb 20
- Feb 23
- Feb 24
- Feb 27
- Mar 3
- March 4, 6
- March 16
- March 24
- April 7
- April 17

January

- Debi (Jan 9) — consulting, CMMC, DR, LLC/S Corp setup
- Michael Angelo (Jan 9)
- Dave Lewis (Jan 9) — reframing the layoff; "my job is getting a new job"; AI Governance education
- Daniel Meystrik (Jan 9) — vendor opportunities, CrowdStrike, ThreatLocker referrals
- Mishaal Khan (Jan 12) — personal-brand monetization, speaker page, deepfake positioning
- Don Donzal (Jan 12) — Just Hacking Training, courseware development
- Jelle (Jan 12) — practice lead, CTO/CISO Advisor roles, equity
- Joseph Carson (Jan 13) — survivor perspective, evangelism/PR roles
- Fletus Poston III (Jan 13) — interview prep, STAR method, mock interviews
- Aliona "Ally" Groh (Jan 14) — ThreatLocker CTI Analyst interview
- Patrick Miller (Jan 14) — independent LLC operations setup
- Brandon Dunlap (Jan 14) — podcast-as-platform, BrightTalk
- Tim Garon (Jan 29, referenced Jan 14) — Simply Secured podcast mechanics
- Deirdre Diamond (Jan 14) — networking referrals
- Kris Rides (Jan 30) — recruiter view, Series A/B, equity-stage targeting
- Theresa McWhorter (Jan 15) — SIM CFL
- Kathy Chambers (Jan 15) — 7 revenue streams
- Spencer Wilcox (Jan 15) — director of cyber ops + second role
- Jason Starr (Jan 16)
- James Pham, Opsin (Jan 16) — Field CISO / account executive
- Eve Vanderpool & Ryan Sydlik (Jan 26) — resume recipients
- Artie & Ben Wilkens (Jan 27) — NMFTA trucking/cargo cyber, CFP
- Bob (Jan 29) — intros to Tomas, Hypersphere, Jason Rebholz
- Michael Curcurito / Chelsea / Marguerite (Carnival) (Jan 29) — Maritime conference speaking
- Stacy Mantzaris, ISC2 (Jan 30) — workshops, ISC2 instructor path
- Efrain Ramos, HackCFL (Jan 30) — community events
- James Azar (Jan 30) — peer support, vCISO BizDev discipline
- Sharon (Smith) Pole (Jan 30) — layoff-to-reinvention, book interview candidate

February

- Kathryn Brett Goldman & Matthew Carnham (Feb 3–5, CognectCon) — MC roles
- Ben Bernstein, Huntress (Feb 6) — Cybersecurity Advisor role
- Kate (CyberManiacs) (Feb 7–11, CruiseCon) — possible role
- Ean Meyer (Feb 13) — GuidePoint roles, rate discussion
- Rob Whetstine (Feb 13) — resume/LinkedIn revamp, job-search coaching
- David Sims (Feb 17) — peer, resume-building LLM
- Josh Lazar (Feb 17) — TechThinkTank, fractional CTO
- Harry Dehaly (Feb 17) — Rein, software analysis
- Sam Bourgeois, DyoPath (Feb 18) — vCISO opportunity in Dallas, deepfake summit
- Pat Gorman (InfoSec Pat) (Feb 18) — pentester, ISP
- Aiden Behren (Feb 20) — chat/mentor
- Jeff Wheatman (Feb 23) — storytelling craft
- Adrian Sanabria (Feb 24) — going independent, IANS model
- Lee Mangold (Feb 24) — HRM/HCM, consulting saturation
- Jennifer (FPL) (Feb 27) — NextEra/FPL cyber resiliency PM role, tabletops

March–April

- Joana Burkey (Mar 3) — pricing/business model
- Gerry Auger, Kathy Chambers, Kimberly (Mar 4–6, Zero Trust World)
- Michael Brett & Kate (Cyber maniacs) (Mar 24, prior Feb 25) — retainer discussion
- Lauren Van Wazer & Obrien Chin (Mar 16) — Annapolis ISC2
- Frank Schalkowski (Apr 17) — career discussion
- Michelle Drolet, Towerwall (Apr 17)

Pipeline Ignition — Hours 24–72 – 5 Things to Do

01

Build the Target List

Companies where you want to work, not just any open role

02

Tailor Your Resume

For the role you want, not a generic document for all roles. It’s okay to use a LLM

03

Apply on the Company Site

Verify the role exists before investing

04

Find the Internal Advocate

Not just the job posting, but the person who can champion you internally

05

Document the Pipeline

Discipline reduces emotional load.
Track every conversation.



Lessons Learned

Post Incident Response



The 30 / 60 / 90 Framework

30 Days

- Stability secured
- Narrative owned
- Pipeline ignited

60 Days

- Network compounding
- Optionality decisions made
- Fractional work assessed

90 Days

- Offers evaluated with clear criteria
- Contracting fallback ready
- Long-term brand architecture built

Your Own LLC / Fractional Option



apparent security

Finite Contract ✓

- Defined scope and end date
- Protects job search time
- Healthy cash flow bridge

Open-Ended Contract ⚠

- Can consume search bandwidth
- Risk of comfortable drift
- Evaluate carefully before committing

Rate math: Annual salary ÷ 2,000 hrs, then add 30–50% for overhead, taxes, gaps, and unpaid admin time.

Interview Readiness Under Pressure

STAR Format

Situation, Task, Action, Result. Every story maps here. Build a library of 8–10 scenarios before the first interview.

Scenario Practice

Live practice, not silent rehearsal as this reduces the performance anxiety that makes experienced people under-deliver.

Question Bank

Know the 20 questions you will be asked. Then rehearse the hard ones until they feel routine. ALWAYS have questions for them.



Your Resilience Stack

Network

Architecture, not a contact list. Built before you need it.

Personal Brand

Pre-positioned, not reactive. Visible before the search begins.

Skills Portfolio

Visible and documented and not just held internally

Financial Plan

Calculated and known and not assumed and discovered too late.



Final Thoughts

Your Cyber Career Vulnerability Assessment

YOUR CAREER HAS NO PATCH TUESDAY

Career Vulnerability Assessment

Fifteen controls. Check what's true today. Score yourself before someone else scores you.

FINANCIAL RUNWAY — *your backup strategy*

- ☐ I know my real monthly burn (expenses, not salary) and have 6+ months banked.
- ☐ I have run a trial month on my "laid-off budget" — the backup is tested.
- ☐ My plan does not depend on severance I have not received.

NETWORK — *you can't build a SOC during the incident*

- ☐ I invest in my professional community while employed (chapters, mentoring, intros).
- ☐ I have made more deposits than withdrawals — people I've helped outnumber favors I've asked.
- ☐ For each company on my someday-list, I know at least one human inside it.

PORTFOLIO — *assets your employer doesn't own*

- ☐ I have public work under my own name: a talk, article, podcast, or teaching credit this year.
- ☐ I own artifacts (templates, runbooks, frameworks) that travel with me, not my badge.
- ☐ If my employer's brand vanished tomorrow, my expertise would still be findable online.

MARKET READINESS — *the warm-standby resume*

- ☐ My resume was updated in the last quarter, with quantified accomplishments.
- ☐ I keep a brag file — wins, metrics, kudos — captured the week they happen.
- ☐ I know my current market rate because I talk to recruiters even when I'm happy.

DETECTION — *career indicators of compromise*

- ☐ I track org-level signals: reorgs, leadership churn, budget and hiring freezes.
- ☐ I would notice if my function began centralizing, offshoring, or being planned without me.
- ☐ I have decided in advance what signal level triggers my active preparation.

SCORING

13–15: Resilient — maintain the controls. **9–12: Exposed** — patch the weakest domain this month.
0–8: Critical — you are the unpatched system. Start with runway and resume; they take the longest.

James R. McQuiggan, CISSP | Apparent Security — Making Cyber Threats Apparent
jamesmcquiggan.com · cal.com/jamesrmcquiggan · Not legal or financial advice — consult professionals for your situation.

YOUR CAREER HAS NO PATCH TUESDAY

The First 72-Hour Runbook

When the incident is real: contain first, respond second. Work the phases in order.

HOURS 0–24 CONTAIN

- Don't sign anything — in the room or online. **Lawyer up.** Severance agreements have review periods — use them.
- Get everything in writing: severance, PTO payout, equity treatment, benefits end-date.
- Solve health coverage deliberately: COBRA vs. marketplace vs. spouse's plan — do the math.
- File for unemployment the same day. No shame; you funded it.
- Freeze discretionary spending until the runway math is done.
- Tell your family today. Carrying it alone compounds the damage.

HOURS 24–48 CONTROL THE NARRATIVE

- Draft your disclosure post: gratitude for the run + clarity about what happened + a specific ask.
- Publish within ~48 hours — you set the story or the silence does. Bitterness is a self-inflicted reference check.
- Activate "Open to Work" deliberately. It is a signal flare, not a stigma.
- Run the runway math: months of expenses banked ÷ real monthly burn = your decision clock.
- Process the emotions on purpose: don't let it fester, don't suppress it. It is a grief event.

HOURS 48–72 STAND UP THE SYSTEM

- Adopt the operating principle: "My job is getting a new job." Set hours. Get dressed. Work the pipeline.
- Build the tracker: target companies, applications, contacts, follow-ups, weekly review.
- Write the target list, then apply on company sites (job boards for discovery only — kills fake postings).
- Identify one internal advocate per target company. Referrals beat portals.
- Commit to the cadence: one cash-flow action daily, one future-building action weekly.

Contain first. Respond second.

There is no Patch Tuesday coming for your career.

The patch is you. The maintenance window is now.

James R. McQuiggan, CISSP | Apparent Security — Making Cyber Threats Apparent
jamesmcquiggan.com · cal.com/jamesrmcquiggan · Not legal or financial advice — consult professionals for your situation.

Workbook & Presentation

qrto.org
Github/jmcquiggan

Left, Center and Right of Boom!

LEFT

Before Disruption

Recognize the warning signs of career vulnerability and be proactive

CENTER – BOOM!

During Disruption

Develop your own personal IRP.
0-72 hrs. - Emotional triage, financial stabilization, & career positioning

RIGHT

After Disruption

You can build a resilience architecture with your network, brand, and portfolio.
This outlasts any single employer.

“The question was never whether your career would face disruption. The question was whether you would be ready.”

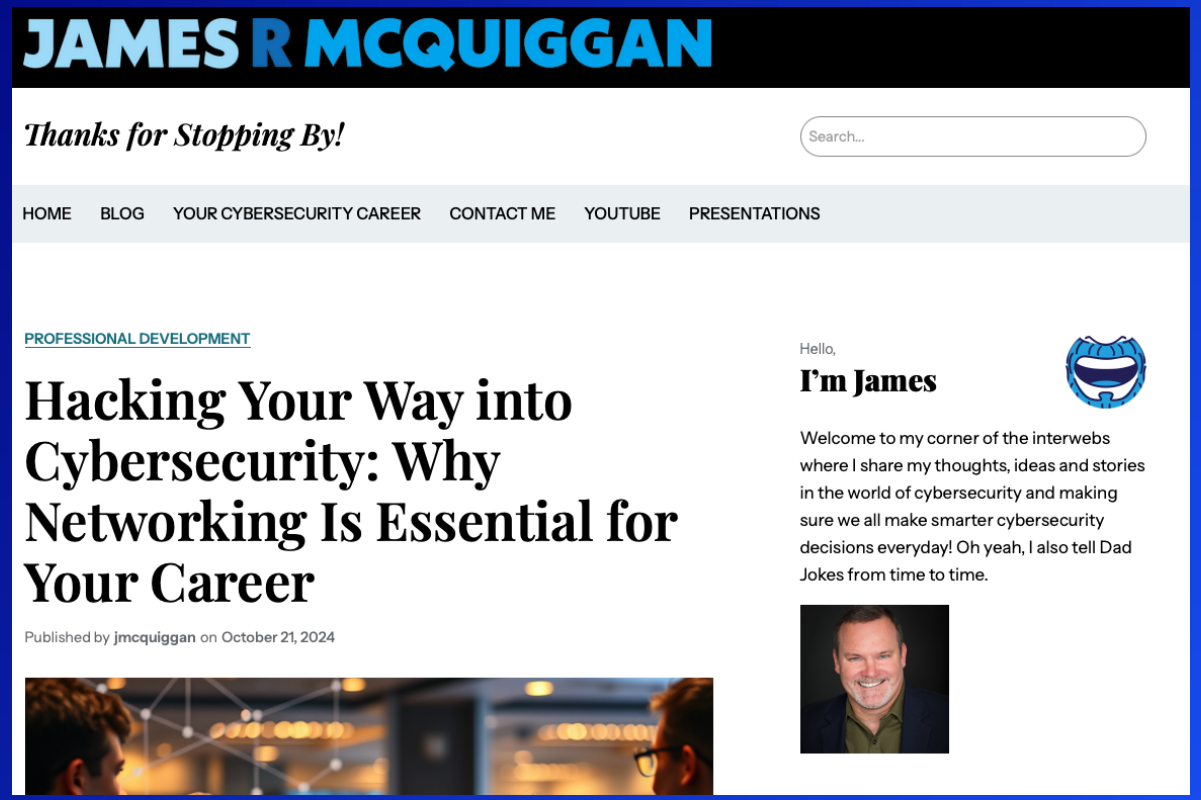


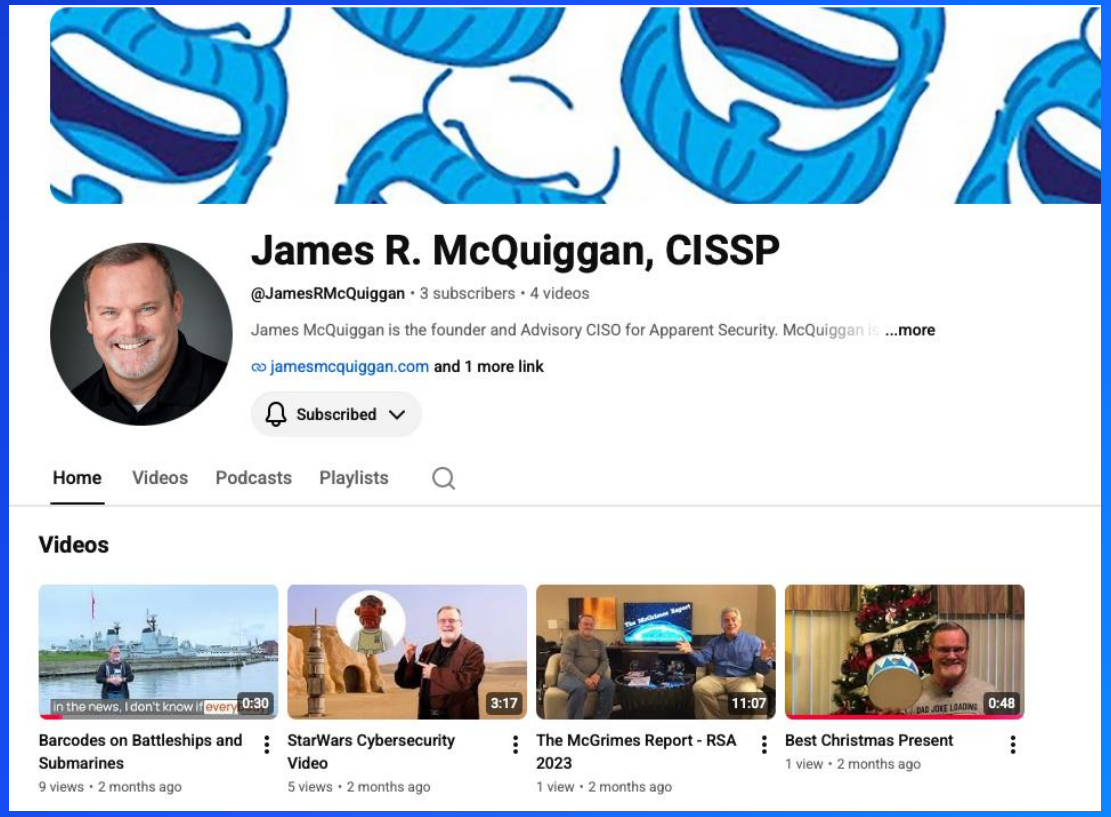
When did you last run a

vulnerability assessment on your own career?

Hopefully, you just did.

Where to Find Me!





jamesmcquiggan.com

youtube.com/@JamesRMcQuiggan

https://github.com/jmcquiggan/presentations